Pinto, a journalist himself, could have woven a non-fiction narrative about homophobia but "it would be read by the converted, by people who already agree, or by people who disagree so strongly that they would only want to read it to tear the argument apart," he argues. The murder mystery, he realised, would be "a good way to smuggle in a message about love and loneliness in the city".

Referencing Rana's description of the change Peter goes through, Pinto calls his novel a "travelogue for the mind". He explains, "You are now being invited to another country, another city, another way of viewing the world. When you go to another country, you know you are going there for something that is outside your experience, but to truly appreciate it, you must put down your preconceptions to come here and...find other ways of encountering the human condition."

Indeed, the novel, and the series, explores a cosmopolitan metro's gay subculture, cutting across and uniting castes, classes and religions with journalistic detail.

Screen-written by Mustafa Neemuchwala and Udai Singh Pawar and directed by Raj Acharya, the Hindi series turns Pinto's cosmopolitan and often emotional novel into a juicy Hindi crime series with nods to contemporary hot-button issues such as the tendency of journalists to err on the side of sensationalism. Peter and Shiva, who work together in the novel, are given a conflict that keeps them apart.

JERRY PINTO COULD HAVE WRITTEN A NON-FICTION NARRATIVE ABOUT HOMOPHOBIA, BUT THE MURDER MYSTERY WAS A "GOOD WAY TO SMUGGLE IN A MESSAGE..."

The highlight of the series is, of course, watching Rana and Raaz, two first-rate thespians, exchange volleys like Federer and Nadal in a Wimbledon final. "A good actor keeps you alert and makes you move across the court," says Rana, laughing at the tennis analogy. "A bad actor will make you keep hitting the ball from one position. To an actor like Vijay, you don't react. You respond."

The 56-year-old National School of Drama graduate, who has been in showbiz for over three decades, has played LGBTQ characters in the past. His most notable such character is the title role of *Shabnam Mausi* (2005), based on the real-life transgender activist and politician of the same name.

"Getting first-hand information about her life was a learning experience," says Rana about his interactions with Shabnam Mausi. "This was a person whom her family had rejected but society voted for and sent her to Parliament."

A series adaptation begs the question: more Shiva-Peter mysteries to follow? Pinto says he did have the offer to write five more books with the duo, but "I have always staked my all on freedom, so I don't want someone else telling me what I should be writing for the next five years," he says. "So, yes, I might do another Shiva-Peter story one day, but only if I want to." ■

–Devarsi Ghosh



ous, you can't play with us," she adds.

Overall, *Sundari* bears the signature sound crafted by Vidya, who first shot to fame in 2015 after posting covers and mash-ups of popular Indian and English-language songs on YouTube where she now boasts over seven million subscribers. Like most of her original material, the EP is a canny mix of pop, electronic and hip-hop with Indian folk, classical and contemporary music.

Her tunes often feature traditional south Indian instruments such as the chenda, mridangam and thappattai. "Everyone knows what the tabla sounds like," says Vidya. "These [other] instruments have such an incredible energy, but we don't hear them as often in a modern context. [I want to] show that they can also add a groove to the song."

The recent success of artistes like Diljit Dosanjh–who impressed international audiences with his all-Punjabi set at the Coachella festival last year–encouraged her to up the Indian quotient in her compositions. "A jam is a jam, and a bop is a bop," says Vidya. "Diljit is singing in Punjabi, but his production is entirely hip-hop. [Artistes like him have proved you can] have all these influences while keeping yourself authentic. That's very inspiring to me." ■

–Amit Gurbaxani